

WATCH THOSE EYES

Computer users, take heed. Cell phone lovers, beware. Those modern gadgets that rule our lives also play havoc with our vision. But how to cope?

■ By Damayanti Datta

As you read this, your eyes should be doing three things: Focusing from distance to near, converging inward to a single point and angling downward. But with electronic screens fast supplanting print, this law of nature is turning upside down: We are focusing too long, too close, too high and too often. As India fast-tracks to the digital era and people work or play the day away on LCD screens, vision problems are spiralling. Computer Vision Syndrome (CVS) is the newly-minted catch-all term now doing the rounds. "The modern office environment—excessive use of computers, bad lighting and improper workstation design—has generated this occupational health hazard," says Dr Mahipal Sachdev, formerly with the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), now heading the Centre for Sight in Delhi. "And it appears to be growing rapidly."

He's a software designer and his job is on the line. His eyes aren't just sore and itchy, his vision is blurred, too. The text dances an uncomfortable cha-cha on the monitor. And he gets shooting

pain right behind his eyes for any work that requires close-focusing—reading, computer work or even driving. He visited ophthalmologists galore, but got pooh-pooed by all. "Your eyes are organically sound," they said. He tried reading glasses, expensive trifocals, vitamins and supplements, dark glasses, eye exercises, and was tested for glaucoma and diabetes. "I think I have CVS, but I can't get any doctor to back up my disability," he rues. He doesn't know it, but he is not alone.

Let's do the math. If humans spend a third of their lives asleep and a third awake, most of the final third is spent staring at computer screens today. And computers make the eye shift and focus between the screen, document, and keyboard 25,000 times a day—equiva-

lent to 60 push-ups a minute—says a 2004 report by the Industrial Design Centre of IIT, Mumbai. If an office worker spends 80,000 hours sitting at a desk throughout his career on an average, and more than 50 per cent use computers on the job—as estimated by the Occupational Safety and Health Administration of the US—it's hardly a surprise that 88 per cent develop CVS.

Consider India: In the throes of an IT revolution, the nation's computer population stands between 15 to 20 million. And they work long hours, too—60 hours a week compared to 43 globally (ASSOCIAM survey, 2007). Nearly 40 million Indians surf the Net every day and 180 million gab away on cell phones. Nearly 90 per cent computer-users stare at the small screen

